



W. South America

El Tatio Geysers

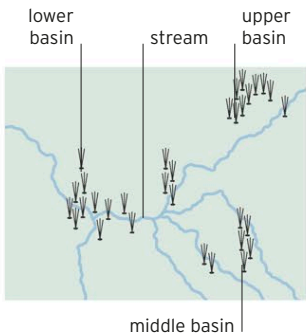
One of the highest concentrations of geysers in the world, high in the Chilean Andes

El Tatio is the third largest geyser field in the world and by far the highest-altitude large field, at 14,170 ft (4,320 m) above sea level. It lies in a volcanic region on the edge of Chile’s Atacama Desert (see pp.124–25) and can be reached from San Pedro de Atacama—one of the nearest towns—via a minor road.

The geysers here do not shoot up to enormous heights—the tallest eruptions observed are to around 20 ft (6 m). However, the sheer density of geysers makes up for this: more than 20 of them are within a few minutes’ walk. Interspersed between the geysers are hot springs and fumaroles (gas-emitting volcanic vents). Visitors have to be warned not to approach the springs and geyser pools too closely because fatalities have occurred when people have fallen into the scalding water.

LAYOUT OF THE GEYSER FIELD

El Tatio contains around 80 geysers spread over an area of about 1.9 square miles (5 square km). Most are concentrated within three main areas: the upper, middle, and lower geyser basins.



▽ **SCALDING WATER SPOUT**
The water spouted out by this and other geysers at El Tatio is extremely hot—up to 185°F (85°C), which is close to the boiling point of water at this altitude.



△ **CHILEAN ALTIPLANO**
This part of the Altiplano in Chile features a dark blue lake, Laguna Miscanti, with brackish water. Behind it towers an extinct volcano, Cerro Miscanti. It is surrounded by yellow bunch grass.

◁ **SCARLET LAKE**
Situated near the Chile-Bolivia border, and known locally as Laguna Roja, this is actually a hot spring with a temperature of 104–122°F (40–50°C). A colony of bright red, heat-loving algae thrives in the water.